7.7 Mental health – Depression

Mental health is a state of well being of the mind, with self esteem. Self esteem means liking yourself and being able to stand up for what you believe is right. Positive mental health is an important part of wellness. A mentally healthy person reflects a good personality. Activities of mentally healthy people are always appreciated and rewarded by the society as these persons are creative as well as cooperative with others. Mental health improves the quality of life.

Depression is a common mental disorder that causes people to experience depressed mood, loss of interest or pleasure, feelings of guilt or low self-worth, disturbed sleep poor appetite, low energy and poor concentration.

Signs and symptoms of mental depression

- Loss of self confidence and self esteem
- Anxiety
- Not being able to enjoy things that are usually pleasurable or interesting

Lifestyle changes like exercise, meditation, yoga and healthy food habits can help to be relieved from depression. Exercise stimulates the body to produce **serotonin** and **endorphins**, which are neurotransmitters that suppress depression. Practicing exercise in daily life creates a positive attitude .

Participating in an exercise programme can:

- Increase self-esteem
- Boost self-confidence
- Create a sense of empowerment
- Enhance social connections and relationships

Brain is one of the most metabolically active part of the body and needs a steady stream of nutrients to function. A poor diet may not provide the nutrients for a healthy body and may provoke symptoms of anxiety and depression.

Summary

Health is a state of complete physical and psychological well being. Many other extended factors like microbes may cause illness to human body. Protozoans like *Entamoeba*, *Plasmodium* and *Leishmania* cause diseases such as amoebic dysentery, malaria and kala-azar repectively. Personal cleanliness and hygiene, proper disposal of waste, safe drinking water and immunization are very useful in preventing diseases. Drug and alcohol abuse of young and adolescent is another cause of concern. Addiction to drugs and alcohol is happening due to peer pressure, examination–related and competition–related stresses. The addicted person should receive proper counselling, education and professional medical help to liberate themselves from all forms of addiction.

Immunology deals with a study of the immune system. The immune system recognises and eliminates the invaders, and the ability of the body to overcome the pathogen is called immunity. Immunity is classified into innate immunity and acquired immunity. Acquired immunity is further classified into cell mediated immunity and antibody mediated immunity as its components. Acquired immunity may be active or passive immunity. Immune response is the body's response to pathogens and it may be primary or secondary. The organs involved in the origin, maturation and proliferation of lymphocytes are called lymphoid organs. Thymus, bone marrow are primary lymphoid organs. The secondary lymphoid organs are lymph node, MALT, GALT and BALT.

The malfunctioning of immune system leads to hypersensitivity, immunodeficiency or autoimmune diseases. A tumour or neoplasm is a group of cells whose growth has gone unchecked. The best results in the treatment of cancer is achieved by an integrated approach to therapy, surgery, radiotherapy, chemotherapy and immunotherapy.

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